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Joel Dorn

The phrase "produced by Joel Dorn" can be found on hundreds of recordings. His list of production credits include the names Charles Mingus, Bette Midler, Roberta Flack and Joe Williams. Joel has been awarded multiple Grammys and he continues to create distinctive music with talented artists on Hyena Records.

Joel was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Joel Dorn with me today for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College.

JD: Nice to be here.

MR: It's great to be here. And I try to paraphrase you fairly closely. You said one time that you have to be pretty crazy to do what I do, or what you do.

JD: Yeah I mean I might have been in a lighthearted moment where I was trying to be semi-profound. I just think you have to have a passion for whatever you do. You know like if it's, I mean my father used to tell me he said, "if you want to be a barber," he said, "be a great barber." He said, "if you want to be a surgeon, be a great surgeon." He said really do — you know he didn't do what he loved doing to make a living so he was happy when my brother and I chased a dream, chased passions. I think you've got to love it, and crazy comes with it. Because this isn't regular work. You know, it's not a job. You don't have real rules. There are rules but you determine your reality by how you improvise inside of those rules if you want to produce records. So it's tricky. And I guess it's not for regular people.

MR: What was it, was there music in your household that got you —

JD: Well there was always music. My father liked classical music, my mother liked popular music, you know, Broadway kind of music of the thirties, forties and fifties. And from as far back as I can remember I was in love with music. During World War II my uncle was stationed in New Guinea so my mother kept the — she had five cousins that were around the world — so my mother kept the radio on day and night to get war news you know. And when I was a year and a half old she used to play me Al Jolson records when I woke up. And there was a record called "April Showers" and I can remember back that far. It doesn't sound like a person could but I can. And I would hear "April Showers" and I would cry. I was like hooked on music as far back as I can remember. And I have no skills. In other words I took music lessons for an hour and a half, you know I took a clarinet lesson. That didn't work. And I can't sing, I can't dance, I can't play an instrument, I don't know how to do the technical side of making records. I can't do

anything. But when I found out that there was something called record production where you were like the director of a movie but in terms of doing that to a record I said well okay, let me do this. You don't have to have any talent you just have to have an instinct or something.

MR: It's something you're born with, don't you think?

JD: I guess. I mean you know I would like to think I was born with an instinct to make records like other guys are born with, you know a great jump shot or the ability to hit a curve ball. If you want to glamorize it I'll agree with you on that. I mean I don't know. I mean I've kind of wandered aimlessly through life and developed a skill for wandering aimlessly through life, so I love to make records.

MR: Well I'm not surprised you ended up doing radio work, because you've got a great radio voice.

JD: I do have a deep voice, or a resonant voice.

MR: Yeah.

JD: I still do some radio work. I work at Sirius Satellite Radio and I do their — I forget what it's called, like liners or interstitial, you know like "you're listening to pure jazz" that kind of stuff. So I still do that, and it's fun, like the Ted Baxter of jazz.

MR: Where do you record that kind of stuff?

JD: Over at Sirius. They have about three thousand studios you know, over in the McGraw-Hill Building, like four blocks away from here. They're at 49th and Sixth and we're at 53rd and Sixth. And I go over there once a month and I cut the Thanksgiving spots or the Fourth of July spots, you know. It's fun. I enjoy doing it.

MR: Okay. Now I'll be listening for you.

JD: Oh please.

MR: Yeah.

JD: Yeah it's really interesting stuff. Stuff like "stay tuned."

MR: Well I've always wondered, who are those people that do those little things. But your relationship with radio — I saw a quote from you it said, "if you ask me about jazz radio I'm going to make a lot of enemies." Do you remember that?

JD: You know I don't remember everything that I say because a lot of it's not worth remembering and I'm just on a constant babble. But what happened was I went on the radio when I was 19, I was a junior in college when jazz radio was pretty much on FM and it was like a new phenomenon in the late fifties through, you know, the late sixties. FM radio, nobody listened to it. It was usually the AM station simulcast or there would be a classical station every once in a while. When the jazz stations started to catch on in the late fifties and early sixties, they went on FM, it was a hip place to go. A lot of times back then when people got out of high school and they started getting into like more

serious kinds of music, jazz was one of them. It was a golden age so it was cool to dig Miles or cool to dig Brubeck or cool to dig whatever it was cool to dig. So jazz radio caught on. And it was basically a bunch of guys that dug jazz, some of whom were radio announcers, some of whom weren't. Mostly back then the guys knew how to, you know, all jazz disc jockeys, you know had deep voices and were cool. We all spoke slowly and, you know, like that stuff. But we all loved the music and we kind of knew it. So it was a place to be. Anyway, the guys that were jazz disc jockeys back then were actually disc jockeys. Now there are a lot of people on jazz radio who are not disc jockeys, they love the music and they love to talk about it and they love to program it, but it's not like the old days where you did ad lib commercials where you had sponsors for ten years, where you were in the clubs every night and the clubs had giants in them all the time. It was a different time and a different place. So for me I guess it's like guys who directed film noir movies. There are no film noir movies anymore, but there were film noir movies and when there were they were the spectacular movies of their time. So jazz radio as I knew it is dead but thank God there are still people playing jazz. Does that say it? 'Cause I don't mean to dismiss anything of a modern time. A bunch of us were out to dinner last night, Dick LaPalma and I and like the older guys and we were with some younger guys and they love to hear the stories. And you can tell the stories and you can tell about the golden age and you can really remember something magical that happened. But if you say nothing's happening now or, you know, then it's kind of like condescending. A golden age is a golden age. I mean I grew up in Philly and there were three jazz clubs in Philly. And at any given time you could see Horace, Miles, Trane, Monk, and any one of a thousand other people, you know, who were coming through town on a twice a year basis. And that was when the music was in full flower.

MR: And did you go to those?

JD: Oh are you kidding? I lived in those places. First of all, because I was on the air I could go to any club I wanted to and I didn't have to pay, you know and that was a big deal then even though it was two dollars on the door — you know when Miles came to town it was three. It was like that. But I was also plotting and scheming. I mean I was a disc jockey, and I always wanted to be a disc jockey, but I always wanted to be a record producer. So I would go in there and I would, aside from getting all the records for free which is one of the bonuses of being a disc jockey, you get a chance to go to the clubs and hear people. And I had started writing Atlantic Records when I was 14 because I fell in love with Ray Charles and Nesuhi Ertegun was the head of the jazz division of Atlantic. I could have written to Ahmet Ertegun, I could have written to Jerry Wexler, but I happened to write to Nesuhi Ertegun. And from the age of 14 until I was 25, including the six years I was on the air, all I did was annoy them. I said I want to be a record

producer, I think I annoyed myself into a job. I produced some stuff independently that they put out, but that's where I wanted to work was Atlantic Records. And what was your question because I'm leading towards something and now I got lost in my own nonsense.

MR: Well I just was wondering about the impression some of those bands made on you in those jazz clubs.

JD: Oh, so I go to the clubs and I was starting to pick out the people, if I got to Atlantic Records, well these are the people I was going to take with me, take away from other labels. You know.

MR: You were scheming.

JD: Well I mean what is this — a business of — I mean Mother Theresa is not a record producer and doesn't work at a record company you know, and neither did Bertrand Russell you know. We're talking about you know like a few labels, a lot of acts, and you know, you're like putting your money on different horses. So I had my group of guys that I wanted to do. Nesuhi, when he asked me to come to Atlantic full time to become the jazz producer it was because he had kind of run the string on his era. He had John Coltrane and the Modern Jazz Quartet and Ornette Coleman and Herbie Mann and Fathead and Hank Crawford and Ray Charles and Chris Connor and Charles Mingus. That was his time. As Atlantic grew and he became more involved in setting up the European and worldwide operation he wasn't in the clubs as much. He turned it over to me. I mean I had to produce a lot of records on my own and really jump through a bunch of hoops until, you know, he felt I was ready to start to learn. I mean you have no idea, and I had no idea at the time, what it was to apprentice to a Nesuhi Ertegun. Because I was really a producer with training wheels, you know. And he distributed some of the independent records I had made with Duke Pearson and Sonny Stitt and people like that, and like a jazz bagpipe player from Philly named Rufus Harley.

MR: Rufus Harley, you did that?

JD: Yeah, yeah. That got me the job at Atlantic.

MR: I have that record.

JD: That was the first record I made that sold you know. And I would come to his sessions you know, so I'd see him do the MJQ or Herbie Mann or Hank Crawford or Betty Carter. And I was kind of learning as I went along. I didn't know what I was doing. And when I saw that he was less and less involved in producing jazz, and then when he called me to come to New York and I had no idea what he wanted, and he said, "you know that job you want? Well you've got it." And he said, "I love you, you're a nice kid" all of that. He said, "you'll live or die by what you do." He said, "we'll always be friends," he said, "but now is your chance." So I had my stash of guys. I had Rahsaan, I had Yusef, I brought Fathead back to the label. I had some new ideas for Hank Crawford. I worked with Mose

Allison, you know I worked with Herbie Mann a little bit and then Les McCann and then Eddie Harris. So when he hired me he said, "I'm not in the clubs anymore, this isn't my time, this is your time, so go get 'em."

MR: When you said I've got some new ideas, you take an artist who's already established or semi-established, what kind of ideas would you present to that artist?

JD: Well I'll give you a couple of real examples but when I say I had new ideas like everybody who wants to be a record producer says well here's how I would record this person and that person. Jazz is not the only music I like, I'm not a jazz producer. I have worked with a lot of jazz artists. I'm a record producer. One of the things I got criticized for, and one of the things that made me successful on those Atlantic years, the same thing, was I took people like Rahsaan and Yusef and Les McCann and Eddie Harris — I want to say this right because I don't want it to sound patronizing or condescending. There are a lot of people who can record a great jazz quintet or a trio or a sextet or a big band. I wasn't interested in that kind of jazz production. I was interested in producing records with jazz artists. So I don't know if you're familiar with any of the Atlantic things, you know, that I did, but I would take Yusef, I would take Rahsaan, I would take Fathead, Les McCann and Eddie Harris especially, and we'd make what I want to say is real records. My biggest influences as producers, I mean I love what Nesuhi did, I love what John Hammond did, I love what Alfred Lion did and Orrin Keepnews and you know, Norman Granz, all the great jazz producers. But they were jazz producers. They rarely if ever stepped out of that mold or stepped out of that part of the music business. My heroes were Lieber and Stoller and Spector and then later on George Martin's work only with The Beatles. And Allen Toussaint in New Orleans, and people like that. So what I wanted to do was make what I call real records but with jazz musicians. So I did that.

MR: Let me drop the needle for you. Okay?

JD: Go baby. Is it going to be something I did that I'll forget that I did, which is another one of my great traits?

[audio interlude]

JD: Did I make that record?

MR: Yes you did. As a matter of fact I think —

JD: I don't even know who it is.

MR: Okay well, let me find the —

JD: Would that be Yusef or Rahsaan or something?

MR: No, this is the same guy that, this might —

JD: You understand that I barely — I didn't make that record.

MR: Yes you did. That's Fathead.

JD: Maybe my brother made that.

MR: Well your name was on the record. In fact, that first piece I played for you —

JD: "Little Sister?"

MR: That first piece I played for you was called "Joel's — oh I lost my page.

JD: "Joel's Lament?" Joel's something. Oh you know what? Is that with Blue Mitchell? Fathead and Blue Mitchell?

MR: It was called "Joel's Domain."

JD: "Joel's Domain," right.

MR: Yeah. Bernard Purdie on drums.

JD: Man. Once again I put the all the R&B guys in there.

MR: Yeah.

JD: People — critics used to hate that stuff man. That sounded good. I made that?

MR: Yeah, you made that record.

JD: Do you know the name of the album?

MR: Yeah, "Captain —

JD: "Captain Buckles."

MR: Yeah.

JD: That's with Blue Mitchell. I loved that. Now this is imbecilic. I loved that record but I didn't recognize that record. Yeah that was a great little record, "Captain" — and you know where we got the title from that? Fathead came in, right? And it was like I don't know maybe middle of winter or end of winter, or something in there, and it was chilly outside and it was raining. And he had a brand new raincoat. And you know, like really stylish, with all kinds of buckles and bells and whistles and buttons and epaulets and flaps and all this kind of stuff. And he walked in and Blue was there and he looked at him and he said, "ahhh, Captain Buckles." So I said to Fats, I said, "we got the title for the album, now let's get the music." And I think I had Zagorski, Stanislaw Zagorski who had done all those great illustrations on the Atlantic Records, I think he did a painting of David with a raincoat full 'o buckles. That's wild. That sounded good. It sounded better than what I remember doing you know.

MR: I love that when you've done so much work that —

JD: You know when you say that to people, you say I don't remember, I don't remember it, and they say like oh yeah sure, you don't remember it. I don't remember it. Now I'm going to go home and listen to that record if I can find it.

MR: Well it was good.

JD: "Captain Buckles."

MR: That would have been, oh, mid-sixties. No, no, '72 I think it was.

JD: Yeah, yeah, yeah. "Captain Buckles."

MR: Well in a record like that, I don't know what kind of — to put a label on it — but —

JD: You tell me what you think it is.

MR: Well it's soul jazz to me.

JD: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Because my favorite group was Cannonball with —

JD: Well Cannonball had the best balance ever between commercial and artistic. Ever.

MR: Yeah. But what I'm wondering is with a record like that, how much thought is there to actually directing the music to sell LPs?

JD: Don't be polite. In other words, okay —

MR: No, this we need a hit, you know.

JD: Well because the guys that I recorded I thought were capable of having hits. Listen. I'm not going to out-Blue Note Blue Note. I'm not going to out-Verve Verve, and I'm not going to out-Prestige Prestige. They did something. I wanted to make records with guys who you call jazz musicians who I think could sell records and not lose their jazz chops. So I wasn't the first or the only guy but I was — maybe me and Creed Taylor were the only two people who were like really chasing commercial records. Because he had done like incredible work at Verve and stuff in a non-commercial area but with great successes that became commercial like Getz's stuff you know, and things like that. But I wanted to make records that people could like enjoy as records. If you want the real jazz chops, I did some real jazz records, but Fathead took all those solos with Ray Charles. You know he was capable of having a hit record.

MR: So do you say to him, because you're not a composer —

JD: I'm not an anything. Use that as a gauge.

MR: Okay. So what do you say to him as far as the tunes? You say Fathead, what do you got here that —

JD: Well it varies from artist to artist. With David, he was open to me suggesting songs and he also listened to the radio so he didn't just listen to jazz. So he was open. And when I started saying I don't want to work with like jazz rhythm sections, I want to work with R&B studio cats like Bernard Purdie and Richard Tee and Eric Gale and Chuck Rainey. I want to work with those guys. But they had a very high level of musicianship beyond just, you know, playing on commercial records. The guys could play. So when they got with jazz guys it gave them a chance to stretch a little, or sometimes stretch a lot. And so I would tell David, well here's what I want to do. Or he would tell me here's what he wants to do, and we'd meet. If I gave him a song if he dug it he'd play it. I never forced anybody. First of all I couldn't, I was a child. These were men. So I couldn't force anybody to do anything and I never would. It's not a comfortable way to go. But as I started doing these and they started working, guys were more open to doing stuff like

that. And also jazz radio at that time, listen I played Lady and Trane and Miles and Prez and you know like Ellington and Mingus, all that stuff. But the thrust of my show was the popular jazz of the day: Horace and Cannon and Blakey and you know, whoever had like a jazz hit or whoever had albums that went beyond the three, four, five thousand selling jazz records.

MR: Did you ever butt heads with Bernard Purdie?

JD: No. One time you know he stopped a take and I got pissed. But I got along with the guys you know. First of all I was a child producer I'm telling you. I started producing when I was like 20. So all these guys were older than me. And it was kind of, I kind of grew up in the studio with them you know? Like King Curtis was a great friend and he helped me a lot, he hipped me to a lot of stuff. I mean I always describe myself in those days as having one foot in hip and the other foot in huh, because I really didn't know. I was like hipper than the average idiot but not hip enough to know what I was doing. You know it was an odd spot. I was really learning on the fly. So when I called myself a producer with training wheels I really mean it. I kind of learned on the job and then all of a sudden, you know, I just caught a wave for like ten years.

MR: Did the amount of records that sold make a difference in your income?

JD: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

JD: Not — because after about the first year I was on a royalty basis.

MR: Oh. All right.

JD: And I still get royalties off those records you know.

MR: So you had a sort of a base salary and then —

JD: I started at Atlantic for $250 a week. I took home $197. My records started coming out and I got pretty lucky pretty early. The stuff started selling so I renegotiated a contact about a year later. Because I actually had an offer from Blue Note at that time to go over there. And then I had a pretty good couple of years, another year as a salary, but Les McCann turned me on to Roberta Flack and I negotiated my first deal with royalties the same week I made the first Roberta Flack record which went on to sell four million pieces.

MR: That was timely.

JD: But I didn't do it because I was smart, I did it because I said oh let me see if they'll give me a royalty. You know, Mr. Simpson.

MR: I was looking at that, I'm a type of person who just thinks it's so neat when you see Bucky Pizzarelli here and all these musicians who can move from one genre to another, and a producer who can do that too. So when I looked on Robert Flack's first record and then I see Bucky Pizzarelli and I say now how did he end up on that record?

JD: Simple. The arranger hired him. I never met Bucky. Let me tell you about that first record. Rahsaan had called me up from Washington and he said, "I've got a girl singer for you." I said, "what's her name?" He said, "Roberta Novosel, she's married to my bass player, Steve Novosel." I said okay. And I said to him, "what does she sound like?" And he got mad and he said, "she sounds like a colored lady" and he slammed the phone down, you know? I don't know what I said, you know, what does she sound like? About a year later — and that was the end of it — about a year later Les McCann calls me, again like seven in the morning, he'd been up all night. He said, "man, I got it, I got the chick" blah blah blah. This is it, you and me. So I said, "cool, what's her name?" He said, "Roberta Flack." He said you won't believe her. So we actually signed her on Les' say-so. And before — I sent her a contract before I heard her. Then I heard a very rough demo tape that a guy named Tony Taylor had made, which had been sent to all the companies including Atlantic and had been turned down. But we had a halfway hit with Les on "With These Hands," from the "Much Les" record, it's the first record I did with him. So I went to Nesuhi and I said, "Les McCann says he has a singer." He said, "what does she sound like?" I said, "I haven't heard her," I said, "but he's insane." He said, "well, sign her, you've got ten grand" to make the first album, which wasn't a bad budget in those days. So I signed her. She wanted to make the record with her trio. She'd been playing at a club called Mr. Henry's in D.C. and she had a working trio. And she wanted to record in front of people who were fans of hers from Washington so they brought a busload of people up, we went to RCA Studios and we made the record and it wasn't very good. She was great, but her band wasn't up to it, the audience was conscious that there were mics so they started applauding out of nowhere and yelling. It was ghastly. So I went back to Nesuhi and I said, "look, this girl's really good but this record isn't." I said, "I want to see if she'll agree to do it again. Can I have another ten thousand?" Can I have another ten thousand dollars Mr. Simpson, you know. So I said, "I want to do it again." So he was kind enough to say yes. Boy I must have been like Peck's Bad Boy to him. You know when I think back, some of this stuff he went through. So I got Ron Carter and Ray Lucas, a brilliant drummer, and Roberta and Ron — she and Ron had a really nice thing and he kind of had a lot to do with the ease of the session. Then I had been working with a young arranger named Bill Fischer and I had met him, Joe Zawinul introduced me to him. And I loved the way he wrote strings so I had no budget, so we had money for seven strings and he said, "you should put a guitar in here too," he said, "I'm going to call Bucky." So now we had Bucky and the strings, we do the album, it comes out, you know, it sold about a hundred fifty thousand albums in a year, and you know she's going to be somebody. All the jazz stations played her immediately. In fact that first record was in the jazz catalogue, the Jazz Numbers series. And we were almost

done with the second record and I get a phone call one morning. I go into the office, right, and this guy I work with Mark Schulman, he said, "Clint Eastwood's on the phone for you." So I thought it was like somebody goofing, right? So I get on the phone and I go, "hello, Clint?" and he goes, "yes." I said, "listen I can't really talk to you right now, I've got Winston Churchill on the other phone, can you call back later?"

MR: Did you say that?

JD: Yeah. Well I thought it was somebody goof — why would Clint Eastwood call me? And then he goes, "hey listen" you know and I go woah, I go, "hello Mr. Eastwood." It's like that Simpsons guy that gets on the bus all the time. So he said, "listen I just directed my first film — oh and all the time, "First Time Ever I Saw Your Face," all the jazz disc jockeys said anytime they put that record on the phones lit up at the station. So I went to the guys at Atlantic in the singles place and I said, "we've got to put this out, I mean the guys are telling me, I think we can cross it over to the R&B stations," I had this great plan, you know, and everybody said like, "back to your office, kid." They said it's too long, it's too slow, it's too up, it's too down, it's too blue, it's too green, it's too everything, so they wouldn't put it out. So now Clint Eastwood calls, right? He said, "I was driving to work this morning and I was listening to KBCA and I heard this song by Roberta Flack called 'First Time Ever I Saw Your Face.' And I bought the album and I saw you produced it and I'm calling you." So I said, "why?" He said, "I just finished directing my first film, it's called 'Play Misty for Me.'" And he said, "I want to use that song in the montage scene that the whole movie builds to with he and Jessica Walter in the redwood forest. So I said, you know knock yourself out, Jack. Wow. We got a song in a movie. He said, "but I'm out of money." He said, "I only have a thousand dollars." And that's not a lot of money to license a song. So I said, "no problem" I said, "you can have it for a thousand cents," you know, like going to be in a movie, that song. So I go to Nesuhi and said Clint Eastwood called and I told him the whole story I just told you, "they only have a thousand bucks." He said, "naah, a thousand bucks isn't right." He said, "we get much more for film stuff." I said, "well it's his first movie, he ran out of money." Anyway so we had one of our few arguments and I actually won. I said, "well I'll pay — what do you want to me to do" I said, "take my next three weeks salary, do whatever you want, we're going to be in a movie." Anyway it goes into the movie and next thing you know radio stations all over the country are getting calls for "First Time Ever I saw Your Face" from the Clint Eastwood movie, and it broke in New Orleans, break meaning it started taking off in terms of phone response and sales in New Orleans. So it was still too long for most radio programming. I mean one of the points I hope we get across today is how much luck, serendipity and just wandering aimlessly into a dream world can affect your reality, you know, or certainly mine. So we get a call from the pop

station in New Orleans that said we're getting a hundred calls a day for this song, but it's too long, we have like a three minute and ten second or some kind of time limit on AM radio. So all right I'll edit it. So I edit it, and there was no overnight then, we sent it by special delivery to the radio station. I said, "what do you think of those edits," you know, "fit your format?" So the guy's hemming and hawing, I said, "what's the matter?" He said, "well, my secretary listened to it and she doesn't like the edits." I said, "really? Your secretary doesn't like the edits?" I got like Ralph Kramden, you know. I said, "well what would your secretary, how would she edit it?" So he said, "why don't you talk to her?" So I got on the phone, I go hello secretary. She goes hello Joel. I said, "well what did I do wrong, lady?" And she said well here's how you should edit it. So I said okay, so I went and edited it her way and she was a hundred percent right. I sent it back down and they said man, it's unbelievable. So I didn't even edit the record. A secretary in New Orleans edited — and Clint Eastwood was driving down the street, what if he had left three minutes later? You know, or something, and he missed the song — I don't know. And that sold four million records and won a Grammy for Record of the Year, it skyrocketed her. And you know, if you want to know like how I do it? Like this.

MR: And when you edited it, did you take a razor blade to it? The master tape?

JD: Well we never do the master tape.

MR: I mean not the master tape, but —

JD: The mix.

MR: The mix.

JD: Yeah, well somebody put a razor blade to it. If I would put a razor blade to anything what you would have is tape pudding.

MR: Okay. You have a guy.

JD: Yeah of course.

MR: But you took out a verse or —

JD: I don't even remember what it was. But I shortened it. You know, I always work with good engineers. So you know, you've been there when we do our magic, with Gene, I work with Gene [Paul] you know.

MR: That's a great story.

JD: Yeah but I mean besides the fact that it's a great story, does it give you a sense of like how brilliant everybody is? There's a lot of randomness that goes into any art I think.

MR: Well I was a Joel Dorn fan before I even knew who you were.

JD: Thank you.

MR: Okay, I have a little story. When I was about in junior high —

JD: Is this another record I made?

MR: Uh huh. I used to listen — do you remember the name Harry Abraham?

JD: Yeah.

MR: He was a jazz DJ in Rochester.

JD: Right.

MR: And he had a voice like yours.

JD: We all had the same voice. You're listening to jazz at 96 point five in Philadelphia. You know everybody was like a pretentious schmuck.

MR: Yeah well, but late at night I used to take my little transistor radio to bed with me and listen to him at night.

JD: I used to do that with the black AM stations so I could hear doo wop when I was in like ninth grade. So I know what you mean.

MR: Well one night this song came on.

JD: I hope I remember it.

[audio interlude]

JD: Junior Mance. It's "Darling Je Vous Aime Beaucoup," but he calls it "Harlem Lullaby." Yeah.

MR: "Harlem Lullaby." And I just thought this song had something, I just loved it. I didn't know who Junior Mance was.

JD: Yeah. Isn't it pretty?

MR: And so that was my first Joel Dorn like thing.

JD: Really.

MR: But it wasn't until I started talking to you about the Joe Williams thing and I started getting out — and I said oh he produced my favorite record.

JD: Isn't that wild.

MR: That was cool.

JD: Yeah well Junior's a great player.

MR: Do you remember that session at all?

JD: I remember that session because Junior was one of the guys I thought, you know, could be commercial in the sense of a Ramsey Lewis or an Oscar Peterson or an Ahmad Jamal, one of those guys. He never quite reached that level you know. I loved the way he played. So I think on that record my brilliant idea was to have him play a blues on a harpsichord?

MR: Yes.

JD: "What Becomes of the Broken Hearted" it became a Motown tune.

MR: That was on the record.

JD: You know, had I left Junior to his own devices generally I think he would have made better records. But some of the things that I suggested worked. Some didn't.

MR: Well I just wanted to play that.

JD: I love that. That was his, and he really loved that song.

MR: Yeah. I think he's since re-recorded it more recently.

JD: Yeah.

MR: So going from artist to artist, how much of your love of early rock & roll influenced —

JD: I guess, you know like I really love rock & roll, real rock & roll, and I really love what people call doo wop, the groups. My two favorite musics probably are doo wop and Gospel. And so when you love something you have a certain sensibility like I like to put strings and voices on and horns on a lot of the jazz records I made, the commercial ones, but the voices were always Cissy Houston and the Sweet Inspirations, because of work they had done with Aretha and because they were all out of the church. Cissy ran a choir in a church in Newark. And I can ask certain people for specific things, you know? I mean I went on to make some doo wop things, I made like a semi-classic doo wop record with a guy named Kenny Vance called "Looking for an Echo," which kind of became an anthem for the oldies crowd. And I worked with Dion once or twice, we did some things and he's like one of my favorite artists in the universe you know. But I think it's the love of music in general and if any of the like Gospel or rock & roll or those things, if any of those elements came in it was in ways I would approach things, especially in how I would color stuff. You know like I really enjoy doing voices, adding voices, layering voices and doing all kinds of tricks with background vocals and hiding them inside of strings and doing that kind of stuff.

MR: And how did that happen in the studio? You invite these singers in? Is there a vocal arranger who works?

JD: Na.

MR: They sort of just listen.

JD: Anybody that I brought in or anybody that I bring in now, you know, once we get that first layer, whether it's voice and piano, voice and rhythm, saxophone, whatever it is — the basic layer where the record's complete, now if you add stuff it'll work or not work based on whether if it works or not works. The only time I use arrangers would be for specific things, like strings, sometimes horns. But voices, even with horns sometimes I'll get like three or four guys and we'll just say like all right, what goes here? Give me some Al Green. Give me some Memphis, give me some New Orleans. And we figure it out on the spot. But the voices — I got a new girl I just signed to Rykodisc, it's like a twenty-first century Carole King, and she's young, she's in her twenties, but she has a sixties, seventies sensibility as a songwriter and a singer. So it'll give me a chance to make modern versions of that classic form. So we've been making demos, and I'm able to do some of my old tricks again. Because there's a young person that comes from that time. She is now, but she's from that. So that's a lot of fun, man.

MR: You must have a certain reputation in the business.

JD: Is this the trick question I've been fearing?

MR: No. I don't think so. But I'm curious as to how a record label might —

JD: Most people think I'm lucky.

MR: Okay. So that they go for your luck, but how would you get hooked up with like say Jane Monheit for instance? You didn't like find her, right?

JD: I'll tell you. See like one thing, I'm 64. I'm not running for class president, I don't care what anybody thinks basically, so if you ask me a question I'll tell you the truth. Jane Monheit had been turned down by every major adult producer and record company that exists. By the time they called me, they sent me a demo tape, I turned her down too, the demo tape was terrible. But her manager, Maryann Topra said, "please come hear her in person." Because I'm telling you, if I would have turned her down, the next person they would have called would have been Stalin, you know? There was nobody left. I really was the last stop on that train you know? And so I went to see her at a club and I saw her live ten seconds and I said naa, she can do it. So we went with it, but it was for like a tiny company, N–coded or something, which was the tattered shards of N2K which was what they did with the money from the sale of GRP to start this new Internet, but whatever it was. So it was a little tiny label, you know, nobody wanted her, and then I threw her in with like real guys: Kenny Barron, Ron Carter, Lewis Nash, Fathead, Hank Crawford. I said look, if I'm going to make a record with her I want to make it with my guys, you know. These are the people I want. Because she's a retro artist in that she deals with, you know the Classic American Songbook a la the jazz singers of the forties, fifties and sixties, you know. That first record I love. Because she had just turned 22, she was in there with people whose records she had in her collection and she was like — but she stood up and she was great. And it was a great feeling 'cause the guys dug her and they saw she was the real thing and she respected them and she was prepared. I had fun on that first record.

MR: Let me go backwards a little bit. Your employment with Atlantic came to an end?

JD: Sure did.

MR: Yeah. Any particular reason?

JD: Well first of all I was a wise ass kid and I was high most of the time so I didn't exactly comport myself the way somebody should. Secondly I had had a lot of success and nobody bothered with me while I was making jazz records for Nesuhi. When I started to get hits with Flack and Midler and Donny Hathaway and people like that I had too much help. I wasn't in the mood for that shit you know, to be honest with you. I got in hassles with Wexler, I got in hassles with Ahmet, you know. I just wanted to be — Nesuhi put me off in a corner. I could do what I wanted.

MR: You mean they started telling you how to —

JD: Pretty much, and also we didn't get along personally. So it was weird. Had I been a better politician I might have navigated those waters better, but I wouldn't change the records I was making. You know, and I work a certain way. It's not that it's good or bad or better or worse or anything, it's the only way I know how. And you know I would mix a record and someone would say make this louder, make this softer. I'd do a song and someone would say don't — I wasn't hired on that basis and plus, Atlantic had gone from becoming the greatest record label in the history of record labels ever, to a big record company. So it wasn't that small boutique shop where guys like me could do what they wanted because that's what it was. All three guys who owned the company were producers. And Arif, Tom Dowd and I, me being the low man on that totem pole, were the non-owners who produced for the label. And I became successful. Listen, I'm going to tell you the truth, I did not handle success well. But also, I was making records that sold. Those records, I live off of those records. So they still sell. So I was doing something right. I was just a big mouth kid, you know, so it didn't work well. And the Atlantic Records I left was not the Atlantic Records that I came to and Nesuhi was gone, he was in Europe, so I had nobody to protect me anymore.

MR: Were you there when they signed Aretha?

JD: I came just after Aretha's first album.

MR: Okay.

JD: And that was like the heyday of Atlantic R&B. Because they had Aretha, they had Wilson Pickett, they had the whole Memphis thing with Otis and Sam & Dave and you know, that crew. So the place was insane.

MR: You had a few years, your son described —

JD: The young years, Adam?

MR: Wall to wall banana peels.

JD: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Bottom fell out.

MR: Really.

JD: Listen, record producers are really like running backs in the NFL. You get your three, four, five years you know? This is 46 years coming up on that I'm doing this. I had a very ugly period in the early eighties, I couldn't get any work. The music was changing and I was still doing what I did you know. And also the structure of the business was changing, so they didn't need any wildcat producers anymore, you know there were A&R staffs and there were rules, and I just imagined somebody telling a painter hey, paintings that are selling now don't have trees. Steer clear of trees. Don't paint trees. Just oceans. We're selling oceans. You know. And it turned into that. And I wasn't good at that. I'm not good at that now. You know like I always have my own companies, I do what I want to do, you know. I do what I want to do because I like to do what I like to do, and also, I

don't know how to do anything other than what I do. So if there's no company to do it at I've got to have my own company. So pretty much everything I've done for the last 25 years, once I got out of that early eighties slump, is follow my instincts like I did when I got hired at Atlantic. Nesuhi said go get 'em. So I got Rahsaan and I got Yusef and I got Les and you know Eddie and all those things and that stuff really worked.

MR: When you left Atlantic did you try to take any of those people with you?

JD: Rahsaan and I went to Warner Brothers for a minute, Fathead was at Warner Brothers for a minute. But that was kind of it. I went off into another thing. I had had a really bad experience making that first Bette Midler record. They threw me off it and then the cuts that I made became the hits and then they wanted me to get back together and that really shattered me. 'Cause with Nesuhi, he never changed what I did. But with Midler, Ahmet got involved and then all kinds of people that couldn't find their way across the street with four compasses got involved. So I was embittered for a while and really thrown off. So I started making really — I mean I started working with Asleep at the Wheel, Don McLean, Lou Rawls, Steve Goodman, Peter Allen, and I made what I think are some very interesting, very good records. The biggest success I had was with a guy named Leon Redbone. And there's another one nobody wanted. So it's odd. Like I don't really think about my career in terms of a career. When I do something like this, you know, where someone's looking at me and asking me specific questions and I'm reminded of first of all what you think or what your view is of what I've done, and then I have my own view of it, which no one else in the universe could have, it's odd at the end of it I have a body of work. By and large I'm pretty happy with it, you know it's not all successful but nothing's all successful. So like I think by and large I have a body of work you know.

MR: You've done a lot of fantastic reissues. You must have a lot of patience. You don't strike me as a real patient person but that's my own observation.

JD: The Chinese say, "the long way is the short way."

MR: But I can just picture you, you must have to sit and do an awful lot of listening, to do reissues.

JD: I learned patience, yeah. Well they're not — I think what you're talking about is not necessarily reissues. Reissues to me are when you take an album that was on vinyl and now you put it on CD.

MR: Yeah, that's not what I mean.

JD: Yeah. No. I got a stash of tapes that no one's ever heard. I have a way that I do compilations. I have this little area, I started playing it because when I came back after that slump in the early eighties I had to come up with something new. Because the pop records I was making and the jazz records I was making, nobody really wanted. So, this

is too long a story to bore you with but through a friend, Bernie Dreighton, I found some tapes he had made at a small club in Brooklyn in the sixties: Blakey, Kenny Dorham, you know, people like that, guys who'd play these small clubs in Brooklyn to work out material before they recorded for Blue Note or Prestige or stuff like that. So in trying to clear those, I came across other collections. At a certain point we had isolated a quarter of a million hours of privately — in lieu of the word illegally — recorded tapes from concerts, from radio stations, from club owners, from guys that hid microphones in heating ducts, you know. And I started doing this archival work. And I put together lots of stuff, like the stuff I did for you with Joe. 'Cause you called Nat Hentoff and you said, 'I got all this Joe Williams stuff," and Nat said, "Call Joel." You and I spoke the next thing we know we have "Havin' a Good Time" with Joe Williams. So it's like that. So I have all these tapes that I either have stashed or have access to and I thought it was interesting because those live tapes, 99 percent of the time were recorded with the artist not knowing they were being recorded or if they were it was like, "can I record this so I can listen to it at home?" "Yeah, go ahead, kid," you know that kind of thing. And now you find that that is the least self-conscious recorded music I've ever heard because it wasn't like you're making a record for Blue Note live, you've got two nights — Rudy VanGelder has his eight track out behind the bar. It's not like that. So it's as close as I could ever get to what it was really like in those clubs in those times because those jazz clubs were incredible. Those dumps that everybody played and complained about? That's where the music was magic. That's where it was created. So all those things you like that we did, the "Left Bank Collection" and the Ray Bryant stuff and the Stan Getz, all that stuff, those tapes are to me the best documentation of what happened in those clubs back then and what those musicians were like on any given night.

MR: I noticed that when I was listening to the Cannonball thing you sent, "Radio Nights." I'm listening to him and I've not heard that kind of playing on even his best records. It was somehow—

JD: It was — all his live records except for two of them were made in the studio with an audience.

MR: Right. They were live studio records.

JD: Yeah.

MR: This was different.

JD: Right.

MR: And you're right, there was something about it.

JD: There's a difference. Oh no there's a real difference. Like if you listen to that Stan Getz record we made, "My Foolish Heart," you never heard Getz play like that in the studio. That Ray Bryant album we have, the solo piano thing in France, that's some of the best

solo piano work ever recorded. And I can talk about these records and take myself out of the mix. I had nothing to do with the recording. I put them together, so if I say this is fabulous, it's fabulous, because the material is fabulous, not because I touched it.

MR: I think some artists may play a little different because they're thinking this could be heard a lot. Someone could be listening to this.

JD: The second you say we're recording live — I made a lot of live records, most of them were not successful. When I say not successful, they didn't become gigantic live recordings you know. Like Cannonball at the Jazz Workshop or Horace at the Village Gate or you know, Ramsey at the Bohemian Caverns, but when you get a live record that works, it works because you can't get that in a studio. It only happens with the audience and the room and the weather and the night and whatever it is all kind of line up in the crosshairs for a moment. The tapes that I have and the tapes that I like to put out capture people doing what they did day in and day out. You know I was in the clubs for six or seven years in Philly. I saw everybody who was working the circuit. And one of the things that used to confuse me was why do they sound so incredible in the club and then their records, while good, don't have that same feeling. So for instance I saw Les McCann at the Showboat a bunch of times. We kind of became friends when I was on the radio. And his records were okay, but in the club he was unbelievable. So when we signed him to Atlantic, you know, I wanted to find out why do you sound one way in a club and another way in the studio. He said, "I hate the studio." He said, "it's always somebody staring at you saying 'take one' 'we ran out of tape,'" whatever it is. I said no problem. I said I can fix that. And I could. So what I did was I brought a second tape machine in so we never had to stop the tape, we had a half hour's worth of tape. And I said, "just play, do what you want, forget we're making a record." Now you can't completely forget you're making a record, but if you get out of the way the, "okay take three, uh we're out of tape." You know, just let the musician do what he does. And if he's got something that he does that works and he's comfortable, you'll eventually get it. So Les went from hating the studio to falling in love with the studio, and then we made lots of great records because we had a way of capturing what it is that he did. That's important.

MR: Well it's really interesting too on the Joe Williams CD. You hear him talking to the audience and all that, and that's great.

JD: But that's what — when you went to a club, you know, like for instance I saw Joe fifty times in Philly. Because he always played Philly once a year, he played Showboat or Pep's. And he was a charming entertainer. And he kidded around with the audience and he knew people in each city. Let me tell you how smart Joe was. Whenever I would walk into the club, I usually caught the last set 'cause I got off the air at one and the last set

was at one twenty. And you know, on the weekends if it was crowded, he knew how to work disc jockeys, so he always came up — nobody said "Joe Williams," the trio played, he walked out, he would go into a song and then he would say "good evening I'm Joseph Goreed Williams." He had this thing, I'm Joe Williams, I'm from Chicago, I'm here to entertain you. But if there was a disc jockey in the room he would come out and when he finished his first number, like if I walked into the club, you know, and there were a couple of hundred people there, he would say "good evening I'm Joel Dorn and I'm here to entertain you." 'Cause he wanted to pull the disc jockeys in, 'cause you know we were all egomaniacs, and he knew it, and we were his guy in that town. So here Joe Williams just introduced you. Are you going to play any more Joe Williams' records when you go home? I mean I play Joe Williams records 'cause I love Joe Williams. But it didn't hurt that Joe was a good guy. So if you had a choice of two vocals and three minutes to fill 'till the news, let me play Joe.

MR: I remember that moment the first time I brought those tapes down and we put them on. I said I knew I found the right guy 'cause you like jumped out of your seat and said, "do you know what you have here?" I really remember that, it was funny. Then Gene Paul said, as we were going through those things, he said, "this is better than dinosaur bones."

JD: Yeah. Well because it is. You know Joe Williams and Ben Webster? No rehearsal just playing. That's what jazz is man. That's what it is. It's not, you know, you don't plan magic. Magic happens, you capture magic. Every once in a while you can plan something and it works. Not for me much.

MR: It's hard to recognize a hit, isn't it?

JD: Sometimes. I could pick a hit track off of any kind of album when I was a disc jockey. Within six months of coming to Atlantic I lost my disc jockey ears. You have no idea. Listen I had a hit with Roberta Flack and Donny Hathaway that Arif Martin and I co-produced. It was called "Where is the Love."

MR: Oh I love that song.

JD: Until the last day before they went to the pressing plant I was trying to take it off the album. And the thing that stopped me was I was walking through the hall and one of the secretaries, Barbara Harris, she said, "I heard the test pressing on Roberta and Donny." I said, "yeah." She said, "wow you've got a smash." I said, "what is it?" She said, "what do you mean what is it?" I said, "what is it?" She said, "Where is the Love." You know, like what are you an idiot. I said, "really?" She said, "yeah." I said, "oh okay." I figured if the secretaries liked it, they knew more about what was good or bad than I did. I just didn't always have those kind of ears. I knew "Killing Me Softly" was a hit. I knew that was a hit. In fact I knew it was going to win the Grammy. So, one of the few times I knew I had a hit Atlantic didn't like it. They wanted me to remix it. They didn't like the

drum, that big fat, you know footed bass boom. And I said, "well that's the record." I actually had to threaten to quit. I went to Nesuhi because Ahmet hated it. And I went to Nesuhi and I said, "look I can't do this anymore." I said, "that's a smash, that's a number one record, that's a Grammy winner." So he went to bat for me. Ahmet and I were never right after that.

MR: The beginning of it sounds like it was done in a big church.

JD: You want to hear what the beginning was? We wanted to have her do like some vocalese in the beginning, this kind of word thing. So she did seven or eight takes. And if you notice, they're mono. We put them all off in the corner someplace, made a little mix of those voices. And then at the end we put them in. And it was, wow. And people said like "how did you get that?" The cavernous — you know and how we got it was it all ended up on one track, there was nothing you could do with it and it sounded good so we put it on. Let me tell you something. Are you starting to see a picture here?

MR: Yeah, yeah. Technology changed I think considerably in your producing career and still is. Was the advent of having more tracks to work with —

JD: I invented more tracks. And I'm going to tell you the one thing I did that had to do with technology. I was the first person to hook two 16-track tape machines together. Because sometimes I was so nuts there were just never enough tracks.

MR: Really.

JD: I was an overdub junkie. And so a guy by the name of Bob Lifton, an engineer I work with, he found a piece of equipment that could tie the two machines together. I almost got fired from Atlantic when I did that because I experimented a little bit, I might have spent an extra couple of dollars. But then the whole industry turned to that. I made another enemy in-house. The technology changes. Maybe I'll shortcut your question. It doesn't really make a lot of difference whether something is on a 78 or an MP3. I make content. I don't care what they do with it. In other words if I had my choice I would work with two 16-track machines on two inch tape. And then I would transfer that to a digital form. Now I just go directly into Pro Tools.

MR: Are you one of those people who say that there's something missing from the analog?

JD: There is something missing from a certain part of the analog recordings but at that little studio that you were in we have our own way of making digital sound like analog. You saw what we did. You know, so we have all that cutting edge equipment on the right and all the shit we stole from Atlantic on the left when the studio closed. We got all those limiters and compressors and out of print pieces of equipment. And Gene really knows what he's doing. He's Les Paul's kid. He grew up in the house where most of this was invented. You know it's like putting a light bulb in a socket and with Edison's kid doing the turning. So we've got a way to do it.

MR: Yeah. And you've got these two things here.

JD: These one things.

MR: Really.

JD: I can only — I have half hearing in one ear.

MR: Wow.

JD: I lost my hearing when I was seven to mumps.

MR: Really?

JD: I didn't tell you that?

MR: You may have told me that but I forgot. Gee.

JD: Yeah so I can only hear — I've never heard stereo. So I have to memorize what's on the wall when we make stereo records. So like if the speakers were there and there, so I just turn and like drum, bass, vocal, you know, zither, cimbalom. Memorize the stuff, and then once I know where it is and I can see it, then I can mix it.

MR: I'll be darned.

JD: Yeah, so technology means nothing to me. And I read these reviews and somebody will say it was a brilliant stereo mix or it was the worst stereo mix, I depend on Gene a lot. But I always say like about people that say to me like Gene Paul — I always say the same thing, he gets the sound that I would ask for if I knew what to ask for.

MR: That's a good one. What do your kids think of what you've done?

JD: Well I have three sons. Two of them are in the music business. They think like anybody's kids, you know, like he's done some brilliant stuff and they also know I'm an idiot. So it's an interesting relationship. Like I've made some records with my son Adam, who is an electronic artist under the name of Mocean Worker. And sometimes — we made a record with Deborah Harry and the Jazz Passengers, you know Roy Nathanson, a really cutting edge like Lower East Side group. And so Adam and I we did that together. So we did some things together over the years. He helped me with a lot of compilations and boxed sets and stuff and we made a few albums together. So in the middle of it I heard something and he said, "oh man, will you just make a record? Will you stop —?" I heard a thing and I wanted to overdub a train — you know those bells that clang when a steam engine pulls into a train station? So I wanted to do that. And I remember he said, "like will you stop? Will you just stop?" Now you should see what he hides in his records. Oh man, he's just finishing his fifth album. He's got stuff coming from fourteen directions. Sometimes I say to him, "why don't you just make a nice record instead of doing all your secret little tricks?" You — and he laughs — weasel. And my oldest son Dave, he's in charge of the digital world for the Warner Music Group through Rhino. So he's in a world I don't even know — I don't even know what he does. But I know he does something. So and my middle son Mike, he would last three minutes in the record

business. The first guy that gave him any shit would be laying on the floor and looking up, because he has less of anything than any of us. So he's in the furniture business, he manages a chain of furniture stores in the northeast, and loves music. He's a country music junkie and a fifties junkie. And it's an odd question to ask, but he always says you do what you do.

MR: Well I think of it because my own kids, you know, they learned the word gig really soon. "Dad, do you have a gig tonight?" And I often sometimes would wonder what, if someone asked their friends what does your father do, "he plays gigs." So I just was curious.

JD: Yeah me and boys are cool. They're my three best friends. We talk all the time, they all talk to each other, that part of my life really worked out nicely. And they look at me generally as a self-indulgent guy who's managed to stay in the game.

MR: I'm glad you mentioned George Martin, one of my favorite brilliant guys.

JD: But only with The Beatles. His other work doesn't knock me out.

MR: Yeah. America and —

JD: It's not bad work it's just that combination of the five of them. You're not going to get that again certainly in this epoch.

MR: Really.

JD: And he did great work, you know great work, giving them like a generation before's add-on to what they were doing. But just with The Beatles.

MR: They're doing some messing around with that.

JD: Yeah I know. I didn't listen to it and I don't want to.

MR: I don't think I want to either.

JD: It's him and his kid, you know, re-mixing. It's like, hey let's do the Mona Lisa again but this time let's put sunglasses on her. Show her teeth. People like to see teeth in a smile, Harry. You know that crap. But once again, you know like I couldn't even — you know I listened to some records that I made, I hadn't listened to it in like thirty years you know, ones that I really liked that I liked the production on. And somebody said to me "well what would you do if you did that again." I have no idea. I don't even know how we got like a lot of it. You know a lot of it is a function of the moment. Certain effects. I did a Peter Allen album and I did a lot of magic tricks on that one, and I don't know how to — I couldn't get it again. It was a function of the people, the moment and also one of the reasons I love Spector so much and Lieber and Stoller's work with The Drifters so much is that — I have the same thing. You have a singer, you have strings, you have rhythm, you have background vocals, you have horns, whatever it is. But when you work, especially on tape and you mix all of them together you have everything you want. You have the rhythm here and the vocal here and the strings here and the horns here and the

background vocals here and the percussion here. But all the little sounds and all the little noises and all the little things that happen on tape, at a certain point they all combine. And then there's like something that has nothing to do with where you put anything musically. It has to do with the overtone on this and the undertone on that and the echo here and the EQ here, and there's that world. More so with Spector's records than anybody in the history of records. I mean not only did you hear the piano overdubbed eleven times and all that echoed, it came back and fed on itself and all the things that he did, but then there's the glue, there's the world that happens when you put all these things together and the things that you don't plan for and you couldn't replicate. You could do it again and you might get something else good. So that's the record. You know? The record. I like records. I like to make records. And that's what that's about, making a record. And so much of it is — it's what you do but it's what happens when you do what you do. That's an important part of it to me.

MR: I love — sometimes there are certain songs if you're in — you can pan things from left to right, like Frankie Valli, the Four Seasons records.

JD: Oh Bob Crewe.

MR: You know, they mixed all the vocals on one side and it's really cool to like turn the thing back and forth and listen to how that was put together. I love that stuff.

JD: Yeah. Well that's what making records is about. So when we were talking in the beginning and it's like I work with jazz artists but I'm really not a jazz producer. I mean I've made my share of quintet and quartet things but there are guys that do that way better than me, and they care about it. I don't not care about it, I just would rather see that stuff in a club. Woops, another surprise?

MR: I don't know if this will be a surprise. I don't think so.

JD: At least I hope I'll know what it is. I guessed one of them, right?

[audio interlude]

JD: It's one of my favorite records I've ever made. See this is what happens in a club.

MR: Check this out.

JD: Johnny Hodges where are you? Well you know that's Cannon — "Stars Fell on Alabama" and he had done that on the Riverside, you know the studio version, but I had heard him do that in a club and when I got these tapes from Allen Grant I listened and I said, oh man, Cannon playing "Stars Fell on Alabama." You hear what he plays? That's why them called him the new Bird for that first year. I heard some Bird the other day you've never heard. It's spectacular. A guy's apartment in 1950.

MR: Wow.

JD: He takes a solo on "Fine and Dandy," in a jam session in a guy's apartment, there is Bird that is equal to that, there is no better Bird. So now I'm going to try and find a place for that. A cat brought it by like a week or two ago. But Cannon man—

MR: Yeah. What was he like?

JD: He was absolutely brilliant. He was a spectacular musician. Real hall of famer, right up there with the best of whoever did it. But he was smart and he was glib and he was learned and he was school-smart and street-smart. I learned a lot from him. A lot from him. A lot of guys resented his commercial success. They said he was a cop out or stuff like that. Let me tell you something. From the beginning when he and Nat first went out, you know with —

MR: Their own quintet?

JD: Their own quintet, that Jazz Workshop with "This Here," the Bobby Timmon song and San Francisco. Through the end of the second quartet, or the second sextet, when he had — what is it, that sextet he had with Yusef — did you ever hear that group?

MR: Oh yeah.

JD: You saw them?

MR: Oh I didn't see them, no.

JD: Wow. The group with Charles Lloyd was good. But the one with Yusef, other than the Miles sextet with Cannon and Trane, that's my favorite sextet of all time. Nat, Cannon, Yusef, Zawinul, Sam Jones and Louis Hayes. They could play anything.

MR: Isn't that the group that did the recording of "Gemini" with that marvelous thing in the middle of it that knocks people out.

JD: Oh man. Cannon — first of all Cannon knew how to work an audience. He was brilliant. He was brilliant. He could do anything. And like boy and boy was he smart. He was a good guy too.

MR: Yeah, and what a tone.

JD: Because he was so successful, guys put him down. And he did commercial stuff. You listen to "Nippon Soul," "Brother John," stuff like that — you want to hear what Cannon could do? And he wasn't in Miles' sextet by mistake. Miles, Trane and Cannon. That's a front line, isn't it?

MR: I guess so. We won't see that again.

JD: No we won't. Ever.

MR: Well you said you've always been drawn to a world class artist that has — you like to see them when they're stretching, early on?

JD: Well I like first albums. I like world class artists who are original. So I've always been drawn to anything from Rufus Harley to Bette Midler to Leon Redbone to Rahsaan. That's what I like — one of a kind artists with world class chops. And I like them in the

early stages, because you never get the innocence again and you never get the reach again. Once they're successful they're not at that place anymore. So the first albums are what I dig the most.

MR: I want to mention a couple of recordings to you and see if they have any significance: Wilbert Harrison's recording of "Kansas City."

JD: "Kansas City." Liked it, you know, not one of my — I mean it's not a record that I go back to but remember, first of all, I was in junior high or maybe the first year of high school so it was a big record. And Mike and Jerry you know, wrote it, so I always had a sentimental thing about that.

MR: There's something about the groove on it that I think is pretty cool.

JD: Yeah, oh no, no, no, it's cool.

MR: How about "Green Onions?"

JD: Like it. But once again, these are favorites of yours.

MR: Yeah.

JD: I like both of them but are they records I would put on? No. If they were on I wouldn't take them off. But I wouldn't put them on. You want to know a record I feel that way about?

MR: Yeah.

JD: "Fever" by Little Willie John.

MR: Oh.

JD: Did you ever hear that?

MR: Yeah, but I'm not — see again I'm not —

JD: You want to hear a groove? You want to hear somebody sing? "Leave My Woman Alone" by Ray Charles. "I'm Moving On" by Ray Charles. Clyde McPhatter "The Treasure of Love" or "Without Love." Any of those Drifters records. "Save the Last Dance," "This Magic Moment," The Coasters records that Mike and Jerry made, "Charlie Brown," "Yakity Yak," "Shopping for Clothes." Certain Motown records — and I can name you 500 doo wop records that I love you know.

MR: Well along the same lines, if you could get in a time machine and go be an assistant producer on some records that have been made over the years.

JD: Mike and Jerry, or Spector. "Be My Baby" and "Da Do Run Run," get out. Do you have any idea what it must have felt like in the room that night? But if I could be in a time machine the first thing I'd do is go back to when Jayne Mansfield was about 25. I think that would be a good thing to do in a time machine, and then go to the studio.

MR: Okay.

JD: I mean there are so many records like that, you know I just mentioned a couple. But I mean how'd you like to be there? I'd just like to be there when they recorded "What'd I Say." You think that would be a nice feeling?

MR: What did you think of the Ray Charles movie?

JD: I liked it. I thought it was terrific. I didn't dig the way they made Fathead look, 'cause that is nothing like he is. You know, even in his worst drug days when he was a young man he was a gentleman. They used him as like an evil foil. He didn't turn Ray Charles — I mean I liked the movie, I thought Jamie Foxx was great you know. I liked it. I like what Taylor did, the whole thing. But I don't like the way they made Fathead look and neither does Fathead. I will see Taylor Hackford some day and we'll discuss this.

MR: Okay.

JD: It was wrong man. Really wrong. What a terrible thing to do to somebody.

MR: Really.

JD: Yeah.

MR: He's still out there.

JD: I saw him last week at Dizzy's with Lonnie Smith. It's Fathead. It's not like we're talking about some guy that plays weddings in Wyoming, it's Fathead. Beautiful, and a beautiful cat. Did not deserve that portrayal. But I thought the movie by and large was pretty good.

MR: What do you think about the digital downloading business?

JD: What am I going to do, tell you I wish albums were here so the covers were big and I could read Nat's liner notes? It's what it is. So now I make — I don't care if somebody buys it by clicking their heels together and wishing for it to come through the ether. However you're selling stuff is how you sell stuff. It's fine. I mean listen, there were guys who probably hand made horse and buggies that were breathtakingly well done and well crafted and sturdy and everything. But when the car came along that movie was over. I didn't like it when it went from albums to CDs because it changed, number one, the sound of the music. I like the sound of vinyl. And I also miss a cover that's this big. You can look at and then you flip it over and the notes are in there, if it's a fold-out you get page — you know? There was something about holding an album in your hand —

MR: Plus you could stand in the store and read the backs of them.

JD: Oh man, I mean see, when I was a kid I used to allow myself one mono record a week, because I was working in high school to save money to go to college, right? So when I got my paycheck on Friday I would go to a record store in Upper Darby which was the town next to the town I lived in, Yeadon, which is right outside of Philly, Riles Record Store, and then I would, for my $1.98 mono record, I'd look at five thousand records before I made my choice. What was it going to be? And there was something about that that just felt good. You'd hold a record, you'd look at it, you'd flip it over, you'd go in

there and you'd find out a new record came out you weren't aware of, and they would play them for me. The guy and his wife that owned that store were so nice to me. They would play it. And there used to be a place in South Philly called Paramount Record Shop, it was one of the few black owned record shops in the city, a guy named Felix owned it. And I would come in on a Saturday afternoon and they'd say oh here comes the white boy again. And I'd listen. And I'd say well can you play me — so finally they just like said listen, don't scratch anything, go into the booth, listen to whatever you want. So I would listen to Mahalia Jackson or I would listen to The Five Satins or I'd listen to The Penguins, or whatever the records were. It was — Clara Ward. Only — records you could only get there. Stuff on Atlantic, stuff on King. It was just a different time. So I miss all of that. But the thing that makes me not turn into a blithering idiot is that I had that experience. So now is now. I make a record, whatever you want to release it on, however you want to sell it, that's your business. I'm just interesting in making the music.

MR: Well you sure did and you sure are. So I've enjoyed talking to you today. I knew it would be a great pleasure.

JD: It's always nice to talk to you. And I hope someday somebody — hello out there in Archive-land — I hope someday some poor innocent child is going through these archives and goes, "Dorn, Dorn, let me see, I like his music, let me take a look at what he's like." And then they found out — a blithering idiot can actually do something. So for all the kids who got thrown out of school, you know, like all of that stuff, there's hope for your children. Find something you dig and go do it because you don't have to follow the rules all the time, you just have to have rules of your own. And on that pleasant note I'm off to help others. My work here is done. Good to see you again baby.